

Passage 1. *An author argues that comedy's freedom to offend must be protected.*

- 1 The desire to smother comedy under a moral cloak has always existed, but in a time and culture where the choke of true censorship has never been felt, we behave like spoiled children – oppression becomes novel when freedom is common. In our modern landscape of heightened sensitivities and moral certainties, the very essence of comedy is under siege.
- 2 In comedy, the relationship between a comedian and the audience is entirely unique, in that the audience accepts offensive humour they would not usually condone. This is only possible because we gift the comedian the most generous interpretation of their intentions and, in return, a trust is born that allows us to laugh at the wrong thing in the safety of knowing that everyone knows it is wrong. Without this generosity, we can have no comedy – merely antagonisers, the guilty-by-association and the righteous. A world lacking the generosity at the core of comedy is a world in which we seek out the worst interpretation of all we encounter.
- 3 Comedy is not a science but an art, and all art requires baring a sliver of one's soul. The history of comedy commemorates those who were brave enough to trust their audience by telling an uncomfortable truth, kindly wrapped within the tameness of a joke. Once the words are out, the comedian cedes all control; like a fawn whose fate is dependent on what the world does with it, a joke is at the mercy of the audience. The fawn is easily picked off by predators and will die without care and protection – just as anyone can call out a joke for being offensive and permanently silence it, especially if no one stands up to the moral police of the world.
- 4 In a time of commodified outrage, in which offence is capital that can be traded for praise and clicks, the forest of fawns that is comedy has become a hunting ground. Crusaders against comedy hide behind a mask of moral righteousness, pontificating on how *comedy shouldn't punch down*¹. But what they fail to recognise is that comedy withers into propaganda when locked into a prison cell of morality. Within the space of true comedy, cultural rules can be mocked and social expectations skewered. The freedom to give offence is still freedom, something we take for granted more than ever.
- 5 When comedy becomes a hunting ground for people in search of easy kills, it teaches us more about the hunters than the hunted. At the root of the choice to kill comedy is a fear that the world is full of mindless straw-people who may launch into immoral havoc upon hearing a dangerous joke, which uncovers one's arrogance in believing that one is uniquely morally superior.
- 6 This desire to protect the impressionable minds of others with our assumed monopoly on goodness is in fact an escape route from impurity within the self. Comedy is the excavation of darkness within the safety of laughter; we laugh because we see the shadow of truth in that darkness and the laughter keeps the shadow tamed. Comedy crusaders refuse to see the shadow and resent the reminder of its existence within us all.
- 7 Comedians are the easiest of artists to kill. They do not hide behind poetry, imagery, or instruments; they are loud and direct despite their vulnerability. Protect comedy and the comedian's freedom to offend. Believe there is enough good in others to know you are not uniquely moral. Do not hunt for malice in vulnerability. Do not hunt fawn.

¹ To punch down is to attack or criticise someone in a less powerful position e.g. a marginalised community, a discriminated group, etc.

Passage 2. *An author writes about the negative effects of comedy based on offensive humour.*

- 1 Some comedians argue that offensive jokes do not have any wider implications – they are inconsequential or “just jokes”. The real-world impact of such a stance is profound and troubling. Indeed, there is psychological research that shows that comedy that denigrates, belittles, or maligns an individual or social group can have serious detrimental consequences. One study even found that exposure to sexist jokes can decrease male perceptions of the seriousness of rape. Another study found that sexist humour made women more likely to view themselves as objects and worry more about their bodies. 5

- 2 Even when we are not the victim of a comedian’s offensive joke, we may feel that our personal integrity has been eroded simply from having been a member of the audience. If we laugh at the offensive joke, we are tacitly agreeing with the comedian and are equally responsible for the trash-talking. If we do not laugh, we risk being excluded or seen as overly sensitive. Although it may seem like harmless fun, comedy based on offensive humour can be emotional bullying or verbal abuse in its most cruel form – even if we are not the targets. Over time, it can strip us of our sensitivity, empathy, and compassion. 10

- 3 Some research argues that comedy has the positive effect of helping to break down barriers and challenge discrimination – usually as a form of resistance. But the success of this “reverse joking” depends a lot on the identity of the comedian; for example, white and non-disabled comedians joking about black or disabled people have to work much harder to make the audience recognise the irony in their act. More often than not, their efforts inadvertently reinforce stereotypes instead. 15

- 4 Offensive humour in comedy highlights a connection between our identities and the pleasure of laughter. Comedy that pokes fun at racial or religious practices, for instance, can blur the distinction between a culture of casual discrimination and humour, and hence may contribute to the normalisation of such a culture, making it more difficult than it already is for victims of discrimination. Ultimately, comedians must recognise the inherent responsibility that comes with the privilege and power of a public platform and consider the impact of their every word. 20 25

Passage 3. *An author expresses his opinion on the purpose of comedy.*

- 1 Seldom does a week go by without somebody somewhere protesting at comedy. Sometimes it can seem like people have forgotten what jokes are. Jokes are not journalism. Believe it or not, when someone – especially a comedian – says something as a joke, this does not mean that they truly believe what they are saying. If comedians say something outrageous, they may well be intending to make a point. And the audience knows this; that is why they laugh in response. 5
- 2 The point of comedy is to poke away with glee and guile at the stuff which lurks in our unconscious. The fulcrum of the best comedy should always foster within us a certain discomfort which the punchline resolves by letting us howl with laughter – at least in part at ourselves for having harboured these thoughts within us. The laughter which comes, then, is truly cathartic. In short, comedy works when the jokes are about us and the best joke is always *on* us. 10
- 3 That is what comedy can do: at its best it entertains while simultaneously asking us to question our own responses. Comedy is not about respectfully tiptoeing around sensitivities or preserving decorum; it is the irreverent medicine we desperately need, tearing down the walls of pretence and challenging the status quo. It does the very opposite of what today's 'responsible' comedy thinks it should do – it offers no compassion and revels in the brief discombobulation of our mental health. 15